

Dominican Republic



Area 18,680 sq miles
(48,380 sq km)
Population 10.1 million
Capital Santo Domingo
Currency Dominican peso
Official language Spanish
Life expectancy 72 years



The Dominican Republic, the Caribbean's most popular tourist spot, occupies two-thirds of the island of Hispaniola. It is home to the Caribbean's highest point, Pico Duarte, as well as its lowest, Lake Enriquillo.



▲ COCOA POD

The Dominican Republic is one of the chief producers of cocoa beans, which are dried, roasted, and ground to make chocolate.

St. Kitts and Nevis



Area 101 sq miles
(261 sq km)
Population 50,000
Capital Basseterre
Currency East Caribbean dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 71 years



The Federation of Saint Kitts and Nevis is a tiny two-island country. St. Kitts, a volcanic island, is separated from the more lush island of Nevis by a channel 2 miles (3 km) wide called the Narrows. It is the smallest country in North America by land size and population. The islands' greatest environmental threat is from hurricanes.

Barbados



Area 166 sq miles
(430 sq km)
Population 300,000
Capital Bridgetown
Currency Barbados dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 77 years



Located to the northeast of Trinidad, Barbados was originally inhabited by the indigenous Arawak peoples. Today, most Barbadians are descended from Africans brought to the island between the 16th and 19th centuries. In the 1990s, tourism overtook sugar as the main source of the nation's income.

Dominica



Area 291 sq miles
(754 sq km)
Population 73,000
Capital Roseau
Currency East Caribbean dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 74 years



Dominica became independent from the UK in 1978. It is known as the "Nature Island of the Caribbean" because of its spectacular and lush flora and fauna, which are protected in large national parks. Dominica's volcanic origin has given it very fertile soils and the second-largest boiling lake in the world.

St. Vincent and the Grenadines



Area 150 sq miles
(389 sq km)
Population 103,500
Capital Kingstown
Currency East Caribbean dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 71 years



St. Vincent and the Grenadines is a group of islands in the Caribbean Sea. St. Vincent is a volcanic island, made up of volcanic mountains that are partly underwater. The Grenadines is a chain of smaller coral islands surrounded by coral reefs. The country is the world's largest producer of arrowroot, a starchy vegetable.

Haiti



Area 10,714 sq miles
(27,750 sq km)
Population 10.1 million
Capital Port-au-Prince
Currency Haitian gourde
Official languages French and French Creole
Life expectancy 60 years



Haiti lies on the west of Hispaniola. In 1804, it was the first ethnically black nation to gain independence. Already the poorest country in the Americas, Haiti was set back even further by a devastating earthquake in 2010.

St. Lucia



Area 239 sq miles
(620 sq km)
Population 162,000
Capital Castries
Currency East Caribbean dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 74 years



The island of St. Lucia has many beaches and a rich variety of wildlife in its rainforests. The twin Pitons (cone-shaped volcanic plugs) on its southern coast have been given World Heritage status. The country's population is mostly of African and African-European descent. The economy relies on income from tourism and banana production.



▲ HIBISCUS

The St. Vincent Botanical Gardens in Kingstown are home to many tropical plants, including the colorful and fragrant hibiscus.